Women Micro-Entrepreneurs in Qatar: Motivation, Challenges, and Social Media Opportunities

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***Abstract*— Women entrepreneurship has significant contributions to socio-economic development. Qatar is focusing on both women empowerment and economic diversification; in that sense women's entrepreneurship emerges as a key factor that needs to be explored and enhanced. Women involvement in micro-entrepreneurship depends on personal, socio-cultural and economic factors of a particular society, thus their journeys are different and more complicated from those of men. Social media platforms can be considered as a great leveler in terms of equalizing the entrepreneurial playing field for women micro-entrepreneurs. Our study will investigate at women micro-entrepreneurs and social media as an emerging field of study and Qatar as an under-researched context. It will investigate the motivations, challenges and social media adoption of Qatari women micro-entrepreneurs.**

Keywords—entrepreneurship, female, gender, IT adoption, Middle East, social media

I. Introduction

Aspiring to promote women's empowerment and economic diversification, Qatar National Vision 2030 (QNV 2030) emphasizes the importance of empowering women and providing them with better economic opportunities (General Secretarian For Development Planning, 2008). The programmatic document promises to "support the development of entrepreneurship" as a means of expanding economic diversification and "positioning Qatar as a regional hub for knowledge and for high value industrial and service activities" (QNV 2030, p.24). Female and work in Qatar presents an intriguing case study. According to the Planning and Statistics Authority in Qatar (2018), the level of education among Qatari women is high (99.3%) in proportion to their low participation in the workforce (59%). Statistics indicate that although Qatar has made substantial progress towards gender equality in the field of education, a large gender gap (60.9%) persists in economic participation (General Secretarian For Development Planning, 2008). In this context, Qatar women's entrepreneurship emerges as a key factor that needs to be explored and advanced.

Recent studies have demonstrated significant socio-economic benefits of women's entrepreneurship (Verheul, 2005) from the perspectives of sustainable economic development (Hechavarria et al., 2019), improved household welfare (Minniti & Naudé, 2010), and creating job opportunities (Ambepitiya, 2016). Researchers have also investigated the role of entrepreneurship in women's empowerment: their financial independence and inclusion in social and political affairs, and increased self-efficacy and self-agency (Sharma et al., 2012).

About 90% of all firms in developed nations comprise small and medium enterprises, commonly known as SMEs; more than 90% of those SMEs are micro-enterprises (Hussain and Yaqub, 2010). Micro-enterprises are run by an individual entrepreneur, or employ less than 10 people (Bhattacharya and Londhe, 2014). Recent studies consider specific challenges which micro-enterprises face in entering and surviving in the market due to their minimal capital and resources. Against this background of limited resources, social media platforms emerge as a great leveler in terms of equalizing the entrepreneurial playing field for micro-entrepreneurs. Some of the social media tools available for supporting small businesses include Facebook, LinkedIn, Instagram, Twitter, WhatsApp, YouTube, and Snapchat (Faisal et al., 2017). The key characteristics of social media – affordability, flexibility, ease of use and reach – have been shown to facilitate the launch and development of micro-entrepreneurship, particularly for women micro-entrepreneurs (Olanrewaju et al., 2020).

This study seeks to refine the existing knowledge of female entrepreneurship and social media as an emerging field of research with the focus on Qatar as an under-researched context. By way of investigating motivational, economic and sociocultural factors, and exploring the adoption of social media by female micro-entrepreneurs, the analysis of data aims to identify and evaluate the specific features of women entrepreneurs' journey in Qatar.

II. Literature Review

Women's experiences since the development of entrepreneurship as a field is marginalized and left out (Clark Muntean & Ozkazanc-Pan, 2014). Initial research did not distinguish between men and women involved in entrepreneurship (Bruni et al., 2004). However, in the late 1990s and early 2000s, scholars identified women's entrepreneurship as a sub-category area of research that needed to be explored in its own right (Jennings & Brush, 2013). Research in areas such as gender studies, development studies and management have since investigated this phenomenon. Studies show that women entrepreneurs' journeys are different from, and more complicated than, those of men. There is significant evidence that women experience entrepreneurship differently, and face more intense challenges than men entrepreneurs (Panda, 2018). Previous

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studies discussed women entrepreneurship from different aspects, mainly: motivations, challenges and opportunities.

A. Motivation of Women Entrepreneures

Some studies have focused on exploring women's motives to become entrepreneurs and concluded that these differ across different cultures and economies (Goswami et al., 2019). In developing countries in Africa and Central America, women are pushed to entrepreneurship to better their lives and minimize their financial hardships (Goswami et al., 2019). However, some studies point out that in the Gulf countries women are pulled to entrepreneurship by the need for self-fulfillment, personal and financial independence and freedom
(Tlaiss, 2015; Zamberi Ahmad, 2011; Al Mutairi & Fayez, 2016). While some research into female entrepreneurship has been conducted in the KSA, UAE and Kuwait, no study to date has examined the motivations of Qatari women to become entrepreneurs.

B. Women Entrepreneures' Challanges

Panda (2018) reviews 35 articles on 90 developing countries and identifies general constraints for women's entrepreneurship in developing countries: patriarchal social norms, work-family conflict, financial constraints, infrastructural constraints, hostile business environment, economic and political environments, lack of entrepreneurship knowledge, and personality-associated constraints. In comparison, a study conducted on female Qatari college students (Kebaili et al., 2015) identified the following challenges they face in starting a business: fear of failure, market barriers, and risk and stress avoidance. These findings indicate grounds for deeper analysis and understanding of the challenges faced by Qatari women entrepreneurs.

C. Opportunities for Women Entrepreneures

Several studies investigated the opportunities of women entrepreneurship. Morshed and Haque (2015) sought to determine women entrepreneurship's impact on women empowerment. In similar note, Alkhaled and Berglund (2018), also suggest that entrepreneurship empowers women in Saudi Arabia to gain more power in household decision making as well as voice their opinions and participate in social change.

With the growing adoption of technology, internet and social media also plays a vital role in enhancing entrepreneurial developments for women's empowerment. Few studies have discussed to role of social media in entrepreneurship and how it facilitated women empowerment, particularly in emerging economies (see, e.g. Beninger et al., 2016). Garcia et al., (2018), explored the opportunities provided by social media for women in the MENA countries. In fact, many women have started their business solely because of the facilities offered by social media, such as flexibility (Beninger et al., 2016). Alghaith (2016) explores socio-cultural challenges faced by women entrepreneurs in the region in general with the focus on the potential of social media to mitigate some of the challenges. In the KSA, for instance, social media allows women to circumvent cultural obstacles, especially gender segregation: typically, it enables women to contact suppliers online (Goby and Erogul, 2011).

A succinct literature review suggests that the research to date has investigated motivation of women entrepreneurs, challenges they face, and available business opportunities. However, no study to date has investigated in detail Qatari women entrepreneurs experiences. Few studies also points to social media platforms as a tool of empowerment for women entrepreneurs. This proposition unfold an interesting area of research, especially in the region. To this end, our study aims to address these gaps and investigate the challenges faced by Qatari women entrepreneurs, their motivation, and the factors that influence their adoption of social media.

III. Problem Statement and Contribution

This study explores Qatar's female business landscape as an under-researched context in order to identify and analyze its unique socio-economic and cultural circumstances. The investigation focuses on Qatari women entrepreneurs' motivation, challenges and their use of social media.
The research answers the following questions:

- What motivates Qatari women to become entrepreneurs?
- What are the challenges Qatari women micro-entrepreneurs face in general, and in conducting business on social media in particular?
- What are the factors that influence the adoption of social media by Qatari women micro-entrepreneurs?

The theoretical contribution of the research lies in refining and deepening the existing academic knowledge on women pursuing micro-entrepreneurship by means of social media in the region in general, and in Qatar in particular. The practical contribution lies in giving direction to policy makers which could facilitate women's entrepreneurship and advance the country's national vision.

IV. Research Methodology and Approach

The study adopts a mixed methodology approach, incorporating both qualitative and quantitative data collection and analysis methods.

The first part of the research will be a preliminary exploratory study. Drawing on the analysis of existing scholarship and initial semi-structured interviews, it will investigate and identify the challenges and factors which motivate Qatari women to pursue micro-entrepreneurship by means of social media. The study will adopt inductive methods of qualitative analysis in order to contemplate entrepreneurship as a "gendered phenomenon" (Mirchandani, 1999, p. 283). A background research will be conducted in order to design a comprehensive questionnaire and plan interviews which would probe a wide spectrum of issues faced by business women in Qatar. This process will help us identify specific features of the Qatari context. Following the analysis of the interviews and critical revision of the existing literature, the study will formulate conceptual models regarding motivations, challenges and factors which define the use of social media by business women in Qatar. The second part of the research will be a confirmatory study, incorporating a questionnaire in order to validate our conceptual models and hypotheses.

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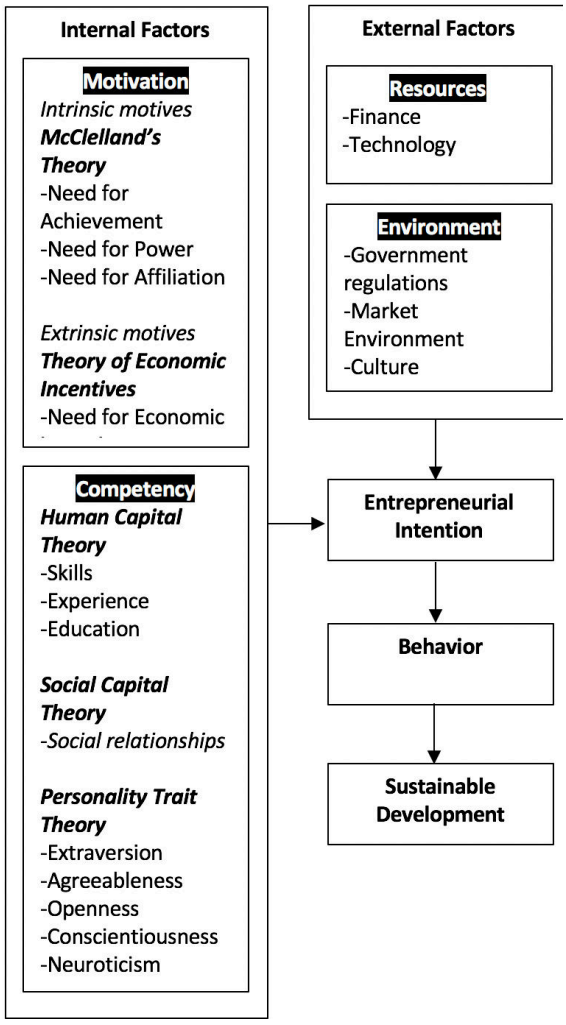
The exploratory study will draw on an examination of existing literature and Qatari female business landscape in order to prepare and conduct a wide range of private discussions and 30 formal interviews. These will provide insights on the motivation, challenges and opportunities enjoyed by Qatari women entrepreneurs. The confirmatory study will involve at least 300 Qatari women micro-entrepreneurs who will be asked to complete a survey. The participants will be reached through Qatar Development Bank (QDB), Qatar Business Incubation Center (QBIC), Bedaya Entrepreneurship Center, and Roudha Center For Entrepreneurship. In addition, the researcher will explore Qatari women's business pages, contact potential participants through Instagram messages, and invite them to participate in the study, both formally and informally. The informal feedback will be particularly important for the validation of the findings. Participants will be selected based on their gender (female) and nationality (Qatari). The diversity in terms of demographics (age group, marital status and education level) will be important for identifying and examining differences in approaches and experiences. For the confirmatory study, data will be collected through informal discussions and online survey questionnaires utilizing Qualtrics software. A seven-point Likert scale will be used to measure the motivation, challenges and opportunities which are enjoyed by Qatari women's enterprenures on social media.

In the future, data collected from surveys will be analyzed using Structural Equation Modelling (SEM) with Partial Least Squares (PLS) technique. SmartPLS will be used to analyze and run the model. The PLS approach is suitable for this study because it gives a "better prediction capability and it is effective in the analysis of a high complexity model" (Vatanasakdakul & Li, 2010). It will also counter a normal distribution assumption.

V. Preliminary Results

Initial research suggests the following tentative observations. Based on the examination of literature and existing theories, the study proposes an initial integrated model which comprises the factors that influence Qatari women entrepreneurial behavior and adoption of social media, and identifies some ways in which they contribute to sustainable economic and social development.

Figure 1. Integrated Model



VI. Conclusion

Women entrepreneurship in Qatar emerges as a crucial topic due to the country's aspirations for economic development and women empowerment. Academics realize the significance of investigating women entrepreneurs, providing a distinct focus on this sub-field of entrepreneurship. Current research examine women entrepreneurship from different aspects; the motivation of women to start a business, challenges women entrepreneurs face, and opportunities for women entrepreneurs. Few studies also reveal an interesting area of research examining the role of social media in women entrepreneurship.

Our in-progress study adopts a multi-disciplinary approach, integrating socio-economic, business, technology, culture, and women studies. This project will be developed in the future in aims of deepen and refine the existing understanding of women's entrepreneurship, and their use of social media as an emerging field of research. It will also advance the academic literature on women entrepreneurships in Qatar and assist policymakers.

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